



## WITH THE GOVERNMENT OFFERING SUBSIDIES UNDER THE PM SURYA GHAR MUFT BIJLI YOJANA, MANY HOUSEHOLDS HAVE TAKEN A SHINE TO SOLAR ROOFTOP PANELS. BUT HOW MUCH DO THEY COST?

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**FOR AMIT RAY**, a 40-year-old businessman from Odisha's Angul district, the decision to embrace rooftop solar (RTS) energy was taken primarily to save costs. The shift towards sustainability was driven by soaring electricity bills, which were taking a toll on his household expenses. "Investing in solar panels has been rewarding," says an enthusiastic Ray. "Not only have I reduced my monthly expenses, but I also feel positive about contributing to a greener future."

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Post installation, Ray's electricity bills reduced by 30%, underscoring the financial viability and benefit of harnessing solar energy. "I spent around ₹1.30 lakh installing 1.5 kilowatt (kW) of rooftop solar panels for my two-storey house. After the installation, my monthly electricity bill has reduced from nearly ₹3,500 to ₹2,300," says Ray.

Ray's story is not only a testament to the cost-effectiveness of solar energy, but also reflects a rising awareness of sustainable practices. Families across cities and semi-urban areas are gradually recognising the benefits of sustainable energy and the conversation has shifted from niche forums to dining table discussions. A push from the government is a reason for this shift.

On January 22 this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, under which 10 million low- and middle-income households will get rooftop solar power systems. The scheme aims to offer ₹75,021 crore in subsidies providing free electricity of up to 300 units per household by installing grid-connected RTS systems. The initiative is projected to generate 30 gigawatts (GW) of solar capacity in residential areas, resulting in a reduction in carbon dioxide emissions over the lifespan of the rooftop systems, which is usually 25 years.